

Master D Goes to Raj Bhavan*

Mr Dharmaiah was having his coffee on that nippy November morning and reading the newspaper that was just delivered---the one-day old Calcutta edition of The Statesman. A news item about Mr B D Jatti taking over as the Governor of Orissa caught his eye. It was a moment of pride for him. And that pride carried through to the four Kannada families of Santrapur, Bhubaneswar on the following Sunday. On a lark, Mr Dharmaiah suggested that they seek a meeting with him; no agenda, just a 'felicitation' for a fellow Kannadiga. And in the process perhaps get to see the insides of the Raj Bhavan. Having made the suggestion, he also volunteered to be the letter-writer to seek a meeting. The letter was written and posted to the Honourable Governor at the Raj Bhavan address. And they waited looking forward to the postman bringing in the reply. The hope, albeit a faint one, was that Mr Jatti would respond, even if negatively.

And then it arrived. A short typewritten letter from the Governor's office, thanking them for the letter and inviting them for coffee at the Raj Bhavan. The suggested D-Day was about two weeks away and there was general excitement among the families. Of the four families two were living as 'married bachelors'; their families were away in their hometowns, a not uncommon practice when their jobs transferred them to faraway places. Of the five children, the eldest was eight years old who was given the honour of representing the children. Thus it was decided that the four men and the eight year old would travel to the Raj Bhavan.

On the D-Day, two cycle rickshaws took them to the city bus stand. And they took the city bus to Raj Bhavan. Walking over to the gate, they presented themselves to the security. The security checked with the Raj Bhavan office and after some delay called us out---Dharmaiah, Krishnaswamy, Narasimha Rao, Kulkarni and Master Dharmaiah. The 8-year old was mightily amused at being called Master Dharmaiah.

An attendant led us down the road to the reception area and then into the quarters where we were seated on a sofa, awaiting Mr Jatti. He arrived within few minutes. We were served coffee by the liveried staff of the Raj Bhavan. Mrs Jatti also made a brief appearance and greeted the visitors. And all the while Master Manjunath just kept gaping and gawking. The meeting concluded in exactly thirty minutes. And we were led out.

The elders started to dissect the meeting and were all praise for the man, his humility and the ease with which he talked to all of them, including to the eight-year old. But the eight-year old was now on to other things and he wanted to know the status of the India-England cricket test that was being played at the Kotla. After some frantic search, he met a transistor owner who had tuned in for the running commentary of the test match. Only to be told that Tony Greig and Tony Lewis were firmly in control and that India would lose around Tea. And then AIR interrupted the commentary to convey another sad news; C Rajagopalachari, whose Ramayana and Mahabharata were among the first books that children read, had died at the age of 94.

Wisden and Wikipedia confirm that this memorable, and eventful, day for Master Dharmaiah Manjunath was Christmas in 1972; the conscientious Mr Jatti had met us on a holiday!

* One of the many memories triggered by 10 March, the day we had informally designated as Anna's birthday. As per that birthday, he would have been 88 today in this, the 15th year of his passing.